

Chapter 55-1: 冒犯 (Offense)

"Ning Fuyi, you, you..." Qiu Yi raised her hand and summoned her pair of curved sabers, furious with rage. "You insubordinate thing, if you don't let go of Master immediately, I'll fight you to the death!"

"Did you hear me..."

"The Divine Venerable is injured." Ning Fuyi interrupted her loudly, turning her face slightly. "She finally managed to fall asleep. If you keep standing there yelling and wake her up, don't blame me for not warning you."

Qiu Yi's half-shouted words came to an abrupt halt. She swallowed them back with wide eyes, dropped her twin sabers with a clang, and rushed to the bedside. She forcefully dragged Ning Fuyi aside and carefully supported Chu Qingqiu herself, laying her flat on the bed.

Immortal power flowed into Chu Qingqiu's forehead. After probing for a long time and finding her internal condition stable, Qiu Yi finally relaxed a little and stood up, wiping her hands.

"What are you doing here?" Qiu Yi was full of hostility.

"Naturally, the Divine Venerable asked me to come." Seeing that Chu Qingqiu was fine, Ning Fuyi also felt relieved and resumed her usual nonchalant manner of speaking.

She lifted her leg, wanting to get closer to look at Chu Qingqiu, but was blocked by Qiu Yi's protective movements like she was guarding a chick.

"Stay away from my master!" Qiu Yi said defensively. Ever since witnessing that scene earlier, the way she looked at Ning Fuyi had become even more strange.

"I was saving her, not harming her." Ning Fuyi was amused by her thief-catching attitude.

"You saving her? You're not a medical immortal, how could you save her!"

"Look." Ning Fuyi opened her palm to reveal the bone-cutting needle. The needle had already lost its effect and turned black on the surface. "Medical Immortal Jiang left this for me before departing."

Qiu Yi stared at the bone-cutting needle, her expression growing even more sour: "Clearly I'm Master's disciple, yet the Medical Immortal didn't entrust this to me for safekeeping, but gave it to you, this troublemaker."

"Perhaps it's because I'm not as impetuous as you." Ning Fuyi withdrew her palm and smiled slightly.

"You!" Qiu Yi was so blocked she couldn't speak. Finally, she glared at Chu Qingqiu and sat down sullenly, staying by Chu Qingqiu's side without leaving even a step.

Although Qiu Yi was noisy and annoying, at least her feelings toward Chu Qingqiu were genuine. She respected Chu Qingqiu to a frightening degree—in her previous life, she had even been willing to die for her.

Looking past prejudice, she was indeed a person of deep emotion and loyalty.

"The Divine Venerable won't let me call for a medical immortal, but her immortal meridians are damaged. You should frequently use immortal power to help repair them."

"This is my master. I naturally know what to do." Qiu Yi replied stiffly.

Ning Fuyi didn't argue with her anymore. Since Chu Qingqiu was temporarily fine, she turned and walked out the door, leaving Jingshan Palace.

The sect had nearly half its disciples missing, making it seem quite desolate. Ning Fuyi timed her arrival for the teaching hour and went to Xuanliang Garden. After entering the North Courtyard, she discovered the hall was completely silent.

It wasn't that there was no one there—there were still a few disciples sitting below listening to the lesson. However, the one teaching was actually the Chief Elder, who was rarely seen on normal days.

Teaching was obviously too much of a strain for the old man. He was currently curled up in his grand chair, sleeping so soundly that snot bubbles were forming.

Thus the hall presented the bizarre scene of several disciples staring at the Chief Elder sleeping. Ning Fuyi paused at the doorway and found a seat.

"Do you think the Chief Elder will wake up today?" the bald male disciple asked while yawning.

"Hard to say." The female disciple with the sky-high pigtails replied with her teeth chattering, supporting her chin with both hands. Seeing Ning Fuyi, she waved: "Young Sect Leader, when did you return to the sect?"

"Two days ago." Ning Fuyi said. "Why is the Chief Elder teaching today?"

"It's because ghosts and demons are causing trouble everywhere now. All the elders have been invited out of the mountain. Even the disciples in our North Courtyard with slightly higher cultivation have been taken to the mortal realm. There aren't many people left in the sect." The pigtailed female disciple sighed. "I really want to go down the mountain for training too, but my cultivation is too low—no one wants me."

As they were chatting, footsteps suddenly came from the doorway. Rong Jin appeared before them with a weary face, glancing at the door frame: "There's no need to study here today. Everyone, go quickly to Cloud Deep Hall and practice on your own in front of the hall."

Upon hearing this, several people jumped up as if they'd heard good news, abandoning the Chief Elder who was still sleeping soundly, and chattered their way toward Cloud Deep Hall.

Ning Fuyi lingered behind, walking up to Rong Jin and pressing her lips together at him.

Rong Jin also smiled helplessly. His originally spirited face now bore two dark circles under his eyes. He turned and walked alongside Ning Fuyi.

"I heard two days ago that you'd returned, but I've been too busy with sect affairs to find time to see you." Rong Jin sighed deeply. "So many managing disciples, and now only I remain in the sect. It's really..."

"I haven't asked you yet—did things go smoothly with Divine Venerable Chu Ling in the underworld?"

Ning Fuyi recounted the events in the underworld and Axe Head Village in detail, making Rong Jin rub his arms in lingering fear.

"I thought there wouldn't be much danger for you, but I never imagined it would be so terrifying." He said repeatedly. "Fortunately, the Divine Venerable was there to protect you, preventing any mishaps."

"How do I feel like you've grown taller?" As he spoke, he turned his head to stare at Ning Fuyi suspiciously. "Could it be that the feng shui of the underworld actually nourishes people?"

"It does nourish people quite well." Ning Fuyi laughed. "Those ghosts' skin was whiter than the next."

"Go on with you." After Rong Jin realized what Ning Fuyi was talking about, he laughed in exasperation. "Little girl, you have no proper form."

The two chatted and laughed as they walked to Cloud Deep Hall. The remaining disciples of the sect were basically all gathered here. Under Rong Jin's instruction, Ning Fuyi learned a new sword technique. Since the immortal power in her body had no specific elemental affiliation, she could only learn whatever she pleased, and she seemed able to master anything. By the time Ning Fuyi could completely integrate this set of moves with the immortal power in her body, the sun had already set westward. A line of solitary wild geese flew past the evening glow, and the vast sky turned purple-red.

Ning Fuyi flipped through the air for one full revolution, steadily landing on the pink light, and returned Yearning¹ to her Thought Pearl².

Rong Jin approached with his hands behind his back, his expression filled with admiration: "Just now, for that moment, you looked quite similar to the former sect leader."

When Ning Changfeng was alive, she was famous for her swordsmanship. Even wielding a broken iron sword, she could move like a dragon entering the sea.

"Thank you for the praise, Senior Brother." Ning Fuyi smiled sweetly. By this time, the other disciples had also dispersed. Thinking about Chu Qingqiu's injuries, Ning Fuyi bid farewell to Rong Jin and returned to Jingshan Palace.

Jingshan Palace was still very quiet. The setting sun sank behind the mountain hollow, leaving only faint red light on the rooftops. Several immortal servants were cleaning fallen leaves and weeds—everything was orderly.

No one stopped her, so Ning Fuyi took the familiar path up the small building. From far away, she could hear Qiu Yi earnestly pleading with Chu Qingqiu about something, only to be coldly refused.

Judging from the strength in Chu Qingqiu's voice, her injuries should be mostly healed. However, Chu Qingqiu always liked to tough things out—whether she was truly better or just enduring remained unknown.

As Ning Fuyi reached the doorway, the door was suddenly pushed open by Qiu Yi. The two collided face to face. "What are you here for again!" Qiu Yi said huffily.

Before Ning Fuyi could answer, Chu Qingqiu's voice came from inside: "Let her in."

Qiu Yi had a belly full of words she couldn't say. Not daring to disobey her master's orders, she could only step aside and glare as Ning Fuyi entered, then stomped away.

Chu Qingqiu was already sitting on the bamboo mat with refreshing tea placed before her. Her complexion hadn't fully recovered yet, but the pain was no longer visible. She had also changed into clean clothes—an elegant dress with its skirt spread behind her.

With the two of them alone in the room, both simultaneously recalled the various events of the morning and awkwardly looked away.

Finally, Ning Fuyi broke the awkwardness, touching her nose and smiling: "Divine Venerable, are you feeling better?"

"Mm." Chu Qingqiu nodded. "Thank you for earlier."

As she spoke, she picked up her teacup to drink. Ning Fuyi reached out: "Divine Venerable, that seems to be for pouring out tea dregs..."

The teacup stopped at Chu Qingqiu's lips. Her face flushed slightly as she calmly set down the wrong cup and picked up another, only to discover the tea inside had already been finished.

Chu Qingqiu, how have you become so uncomposed? she chided herself silently, then set the teacup down on the table with a thunk and stopped drinking altogether.

"The bone-cutting needle was given to you by Jiang Li?" Chu Qingqiu maintained the coldness in her voice to preserve her dignity.

"Yes." Ning Fuyi replied.

"This Medical Immortal Jiang has many schemes." Chu Qingqiu shook her head.

"May I ask when the Divine Venerable sustained these old injuries?" Ning Fuyi tentatively asked.

"No." Chu Qingqiu answered decisively.

Very well. Ning Fuyi bit her lip—she should probably leave now. But for some reason, she wanted to stay here a bit longer, so she searched for topics: "Qiu Yi seemed to have some misunderstanding about us earlier. She must be harboring resentment. Should I explain things to her again?"

"No need. I've already explained everything to her." Chu Qingqiu rarely sighed. "She's not throwing a tantrum because of this, but because I won't let her go down the mountain to eliminate demons."

"If she wants to go train, why not let her go?" Ning Fuyi was puzzled.

"If she went for training, I naturally wouldn't stop her. But she wants to go down the mountain for revenge. Whether it's love or hate, too much of either makes one lose rationality and always spoils things."

"Revenge?" Ning Fuyi was surprised. In her previous life, she had never cared about others' affairs. She only knew that Qiu Yi was the only disciple Chu Qingqiu had ever taken, and she had only envied her.

"Yes, revenge." Chu Qingqiu spoke slowly and softly, her eyelashes slightly raised. "Do you know of the Cangyun Kingdom³?"

"I've only heard Qiu Yi mention it." There were so many kingdoms and states in the mortal realm—countless as cattle—that Ning Fuyi had never bothered to remember them seriously.

"The Cangyun Kingdom was destroyed decades ago, so it's normal that you don't know of it." Chu Qingqiu raised her hand and created a white mist. The mist curled and reformed, presenting a topographical map.

"Cangyun Kingdom was adjacent to the Demon Abyss⁴. Originally, it was fertile land where people lived in peace and contentment with few wars. However, one day it suffered a demonic calamity. To annex Cangyun Kingdom, the demon race released demonic energy within Cangyun's borders, corrupting many ordinary people. Plagues spread everywhere, and the dead transformed into zombies that would turn anyone they bit into zombies as well."

"Later, the Emperor of Cangyun had no choice but to send armies throughout the nation to suppress them. However, the speed of zombie transformation was too terrifying. The armies were useless and even strengthened the zombie hordes, leading to hundreds of thousands of zombies attacking the capital together. I was still in closed-door cultivation at the time and learned of this too late. When I reached Cangyun, the palace had already become ruins. Everyone in the palace was dead, leaving only a city full of zombies and one baby girl hidden in a rice jar, crying loudly."

"From the luxurious clothes she wore and the jade lock at her chest, she should have been a princess from the palace, hidden in the rice jar to escape disaster."

Ning Fuyi's heart clenched as she listened.

"In the end, I had no choice but to cast a spell to seal the entire city and use great fire to burn the capital and all those zombies to ash. Seeing that the child was only of tender years, I felt compassion. Noticing her bones and aptitude were quite good, I brought her back to Purple Cloud Peak and took her as my disciple."

"That was Qiu Yi?" Ning Fuyi asked.

"That was Qiu Yi." Chu Qingqiu answered.

"Although she was only of tender years at the time, she remembered that day's carnage quite clearly. Therefore, she has always harbored hatred toward the demon race. Whenever anything involves eliminating demons, she becomes abnormally obsessed."

"I never knew." Ning Fuyi felt somewhat dazed. The taste of watching loved ones die tragically and one's country fall must be very unpleasant indeed.

"So it is that I act for the world, yet all in the world suffer." Chu Qingqiu said softly.

Footnotes:

1. **相思 (Yearning)** - The name of Ning Fuyi's sword.
2. **一念珠 (Thought Pearl)** - A storage device that can hold items in a pocket dimension.
3. **苍云国 (Cangyun Kingdom)** - Literally "Gray Cloud Kingdom," a mortal realm nation that was destroyed by demons.
4. **魔窟 (Demon Abyss)** - The realm where demons reside, similar to the underworld but specifically for demonic beings.